

So you're thinking about marketing

The short version — written for you, not about you.

Everything that matters, none of the bits written for your parents.

We scored twenty-seven careers on how exposed they are to AI.

Content and social execution: **8.2** out of 10.

Brand strategy and marketing leadership: **5.5**.

And here's what makes marketing different from nursing, law or accounting: it has no protection at all built into it. None. Everything you get, you earn personally.

The 60-second version

- The destinations are good. Brand leadership, analytics, product marketing all hold up.
 - Content and campaign execution is among the most automated professional work we score.
 - **Nobody's being fired.** Roles just stop being refilled, and the work lands on whoever's left.
 - Marketing has **two of six protection factors at zero, permanently.**
 - The genuinely useful bit: AI-fluent marketers earn **15–30% more** right now.
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The thing to understand first

Most of our profiles explain why a career is protected. This one's worth reading for the opposite reason.

Two of our six factors are zero for everyone in marketing, forever:

No licence. There's no professional body, no statute reserving any marketing activity to a qualified human. Nothing stops a company replacing marketing work with software the moment the software is good enough.

No physical requirement. All of it can be done from anywhere — which means all of it can be done by anything.

Compare accounting: only a licensed CPA can sign an audit. Compare nursing: staffing ratios are written into law. Compare an electrician: you can't rewire a house through a screen.

Marketing has none of that. So your entire protection has to come from trust, judgment and accountability — and all three only arrive with seniority.

A nurse is protected on day one. A marketer is protected once someone trusts them with a number. At 22, that's nobody.

How the displacement actually works

This is subtler than "AI took the jobs," and it's the most useful thing in this document.

The Content Marketing Institute surveyed 644 marketers in early 2026. What they found:

- Only about 11% of organisations have actually replaced anyone with AI
- But 76% of marketers are doing the work of more than one job
- And 50% have taken on new responsibilities with no promotion or pay rise

Nobody gets fired. Layoffs, people leaving, and slow hiring shrink the team — and the work gets redistributed to whoever stays. CMI calls it a *ghost workforce*.

Which means a profession can look completely healthy on headcount while the actual job gets considerably worse. There's no announcement. The vacancies just stop appearing.

And it explains the confusing bit: overall marketing hiring is *growing*. Companies want more marketers. They want experienced ones who can direct AI work — one in three companies is cutting entry-level hiring specifically, with cuts outpacing increases by about two and a half to one.

The scores

TRACK	SCORE
Brand strategy / leadership	5.5
Marketing science / analytics	6.2
Product marketing	6.5
Campaign management	7.2
Content & social execution	8.2

The distinction that matters: **producing marketing versus deciding marketing**. Generating content isn't a job any more — it's a prompt. Deciding what should exist, and answering for whether it worked, still is.

The genuinely good news

AI-fluent marketers are currently earning 15-30% more than peers in equivalent roles, and industry salary data says that gap is widening.

That's the clearest evidence anywhere in our whole index that becoming genuinely good with these tools pays — now, not eventually.

Also real: global ad spend is approaching a trillion dollars. Employers posted over 376,000 marketing and creative jobs in 2025. Digital marketing roles are projected to grow around 6%. And a whole category of AI marketing roles — automation, AI-integrated specialisms, data-driven creative direction — barely existed in 2024 and pays substantially more.

Almost nobody entering the field is aiming at those.

The question that decides this

Do you want to make things, or decide things?

Be honest, because they lead to opposite ends of that table.

If it's the *making* — writing, designing, producing content, the craft of communication — that instinct points directly at the 8.2 end. It's also the most common reason people pick marketing.

If it's *deciding* — what should we say, to whom, why, and did it work — **you're pointed at the protected end, and that end is genuinely good.**

What we won't soften

The entry tier is hard right now, and the data is specific: one in three companies reducing entry-level hiring, layoffs up 30% on two years ago, 75% of marketers saying it's harder to find a job.

The workload thing is real and nobody talks about it. Three-quarters doing more than one job. Half taking on more work with no more pay. That's the actual experience of the profession

right now and it doesn't show up in any employment statistic.

Career development is thin — only about one in four marketers is very satisfied with it.

And the job titles are chaos. The same work has five different names with huge pay gaps between them, which makes it genuinely hard to tell whether an offer is any good.

What actually works

Not marketing on its own. Marketing **plus** something.

Analytics or marketing science. Better score, better pay, far fewer applicants. The people building the models are scarcer than the people running them.

A domain — healthcare, financial services, industrial. The domain knowledge is the protection, not the marketing.

Product marketing — sits close to the product and the customer, needs real understanding.

Or point it at commercial leadership, where being accountable for revenue is what protects you.

The version that doesn't work: a general marketing degree, no specialisation, no placement, aimed at a content job. That's the weakest combination in this profile and the most commonly taken.

What actually matters when picking a course

- **How much is quantitative, and is it compulsory?** Single best predictor. Analytics is the judgment layer; content production is the automated one.
 - **Is there a real analytics or marketing science pathway?**
 - **Placement** — guaranteed or competitive?
 - **Do they teach you to use AI tools and check them?**
 - **What job titles do graduates have at six months?** "Marketing coordinator" and "marketing analytics manager" are very different outcomes.
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Two things worth doing

Run something real. A campaign, a channel, a small product, an account that actually grew. Anything with a number attached. In a field with no credential, results are the credential — and almost nobody your age has any.

Then find someone two or three years into marketing and ask what they actually do all day, and how many people's jobs it adds up to. The answer will tell you more than any brochure.

If you want to go further — three things worth twenty minutes

- **2026 Career and Salary Outlook: Content and Marketing Professionals** — read this one. 644 marketers surveyed, and it's where every number above comes from.
 - **The ghost workforce** — the summary version, and a good explanation of why displacement here is so hard to see.
 - **Digital marketing hiring trends 2026** — where demand actually is by role. It's from a recruiting firm, so read it for direction rather than as neutral.
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There's a longer version behind this — full scores by track, how they were worked out, the honest downsides, what to ask a program, and where we might be wrong. Your parents have it.